

INFLUENCE

The Psychology of
Persuasion

ROBERT B. CIALDINI, PH.D



The Big “So What”

Based on years of research, Cialdini discovered 6 key principles of persuasion which lead people to say “yes” automatically. Understanding these principles and associated techniques can help you to improve your influence and concurrently guard against others’ manipulation.



Introduction



Fixed-action patterns. Both animals and humans have certain behaviors that are pre-programmed and activated once specific cues are triggered.

- Such patterns are essential for our survival. There are simply too many environmental stimuli for our brains to process everything. Using specific cues as shortcuts, we can react quickly without processing all the information. For example, a flash of sharp teeth or blade will signify “danger”, causing us to step back instinctively without second thought.
- The same predictable patterns are behind animals’ mating rituals and defence mechanisms. A mother turkey will care lovingly for a chick that makes a “cheep-cheep” sound (a good indicator that the chick is healthy), but will ignore or even kill a chick that doesn’t chirp. The “cheep-cheep” sound is so powerful that the turkey will even care for a predator-shaped stuffed toy if it makes the sound.



In short, we tend to respond in an mechanical, predictable way to certain triggers or stimuli. With the right cues, we’ll say “yes” automatically without conscious thought.

KEY QUOTES

“We must very often use our stereotypes, our rules of thumb to classify things according to a few features and then to respond mindlessly when one or another of these trigger features is present.”

“Fixed-action patterns...occur in virtually the same fashion and in the same order every time.”

- For example, you're more likely to comply to a request if the other party offers a reason using the word "because". You'll also estimate how good/heavy/valuable something is, just by comparing it with something you've just seen (the "contrast principle").
- We fall back on such shortcuts more when we're tired, stressed, distracted or rushed. With technological advancement, a faster pace of life and information-overload, we've become increasingly reliant on this primal way of making quick decisions.



After many years of research, Cialdini discovered 6 key weapons of influence, each built on a psychological principle of persuasion.

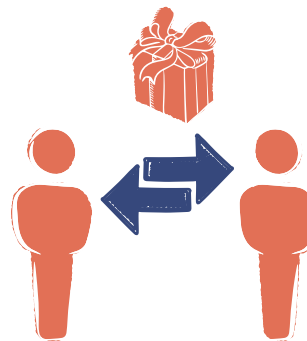
- Underlying all 6 principles is "material self-interest", i.e. everyone wants to pay the least, yet get the most.
- Each principle can be used to bring positive change or deceive others, depending on the intention of the user. Being aware of these weapons allow us to guard against "compliance professionals" (e.g. salespeople or marketers) who specialize in getting people to comply with their requests.



The 6 Principles of Persuasion

Reciprocity

When someone does something for us or gives us something, we feel obliged to repay in kind.



The Reciprocity Principle is a vital part of human society:

- It makes it less risky for people to offer help or goodwill to others; it facilitates sharing and cooperation which supports mankind's social advancement.
- You'll feel indebted to repay a favor even if you don't like the person.

KEY QUOTES

"We have created an environment so complex, fast-paced, and information laden that we must increasingly deal with it in the fashion of the animals we long ago transcended."

"A favor is to be met with another favor; it is not to be met with neglect, and certainly not with attack."



Reciprocity has been widely tested and applied in various settings:

- In an experiment, a man intentionally gave a free bottle of Coca-Cola to some participants but not others. Those who received the free drink later bought twice as many number of raffle tickets from the man as a favor, compared with those who didn't.
- In sales, free samples are commonly used to trigger the reciprocity principle and let customers try the product. It's also proven that you're more likely to get a donation if you give someone a small gift first.
- Reciprocity even works in politics and war. During World War I, a soldier was released after he shared his only piece of bread with the enemy who had captured him.



When you receive a concession, you'll also feel obliged to give a concession. There are 2 related compliance techniques built on this principle: "reject-then-retreat" and "large-then-small".

- Basically, the other party starts with a larger request (e.g. present an item for \$20). If you reject the request, he/she makes a smaller request (e.g. present a less valuable item for \$5). In this case, you're likely to agree the 2nd request because (a) the requesting party seems to have made a concession, which triggers you to give a concession by switching from "no" to "yes" and (b) by perceptual contrast, the 2nd request seems smaller.
- The larger the initial request (within reasonable limits), the bigger the concession seems. The requester wins by default—if we accept the initial request, he/she gets a better deal; if we only accept the 2nd request, they still get a deal.



Interestingly, the receiving party doesn't usually feel cheated and even responds positively. Such techniques have been found to (a) increase the chance of *getting* an agreement, (b) increase the chance of the agreement being *fulfilled*, and (c) increase the *satisfaction level* of the receiving party. This is because:

- When we believe someone gave us a concession, we feel responsible for the outcome and tend to honor it.

KEY QUOTES

"A person who feels responsible for the terms of a contract will be more likely to live up to the contract."

- We also tend to feel more satisfied with the arrangement, and are hence more likely to repeat it in the future.



However, this principle can also be used against us.

- Unsolicited debts. We may be pressured to accept something that we don't want or dislike, yet feel compelled to repay it. For example, you may grudgingly accept a snack that someone bought for you, then later find yourself cornered to return the favor, resulting in a lose-lose situation. Or, you may receive an uninvited gift in the mail with a request for donation.
- Unfair exchanges. A small gift or favor may be used to trigger a much larger favor or purchase in return.



How to say no. It doesn't make sense to reject all favors, gifts and concessions, since many are genuine and benefit us. The key here is to identify the true intention of the requester.

- Start by accepting the favor or gift offered to you.
- If the person starts to make demands/requests after that, simply redefine the situation mentally. Recognize that it's not a real favor or concession, but a persuasive manoeuvre—this frees you from your sense of obligation and makes it easier to say “no”.

Consistency

Once we take a stand or make a choice, we feel compelled to behave consistently with our earlier commitment, and to justify our own decisions so we feel better about them. This need to appear consistent (to ourselves and others) can make us act contrary to our best interest.



Consistency is an important motivator because:

- Most cultures value personal consistency. Consistency is associated with clarity, reliability or honesty, while inconsistency is associated with indecision, confusion or deceit.

KEY QUOTES

“Another person can trigger a feeling of indebtedness by doing us an uninvited favor.”

“The rule says that favors are to be met with favors; it does not require that tricks be met with favors.”

“We all fool ourselves from time to time in order to keep our thoughts and beliefs consistent with what we have already done or decided.”

- It provides a mental shortcut to minimize the amount of thinking required—once we’ve decided on something, it’s easier to use it to guide future decisions.
- It also allows us to avoid difficult realities that we’d rather not deal with, e.g. we may prefer to believe that our current solutions will work, rather than find alternatives to a tough challenge.



For the consistency principle to kick in, a real commitment must be made, with a fundamental shift in self-image. This involves several components.

- Active. When you actively do something in support of a position or decision, you become more committed to it. A written statement can be very powerful as it makes the person’s views visible/concrete, and can be shown to others.
- Public. The more public your stand, the more reluctant you’ll be to change it, for fear of appearing inconsistent. In a study, students were asked to make choices before being given conflicting data. Those who wrote down and signed next to their choices were the most unwilling to change their views, while those who didn’t write down their choices were most willing to change them.
- Effortful. The more effort you’ve put into your choice, the more you will value and justify it. This is why tough initiation programs are so popular in tribal and fraternal societies—the more people have to endure to secure their membership, the more they’re committed to it.
- Inner choice. When we choose something without strong external pressures (i.e. huge rewards or huge threats), we feel more ownership of that decision and will stick to it willingly. However, if we believe that we did something just to get a reward or to avoid a threat, our fundamental self-image is unchanged and we’ll drop these behaviors once the reward or threat is removed.



Once a firm commitment is made, there’ll be lasting changes to our choices and behaviors. The commitment “grows legs” as we find new ways to justify it and make new choices in various situations to stay consistent.

KEY QUOTES

“There are certain disturbing things we simply would rather not realize... automatic consistency can supply a safe hiding place from those troubling realizations.”

“Our best evidence of what people truly feel and believe comes less from their words than from their deeds.”

“It appears that commitments are most effective in changing a person’s self-image and future behavior when they are active, public and effortful.”

“We accept inner responsibility for a behavior when we think we have chosen to perform it in the absence of strong outside pressures.”



Unfortunately, blind consistency is often used against us.

- In retail, toy manufacturers may advertise certain toys during the Christmas season but understock them. Parents find themselves buying substitutes during Christmas, then getting another set of the originally-intended toys when they're back in stock after Christmas—just to keep their promises to the kids.
- A common sales strategy is to secure a small (even loss-making) purchase, then use it to open the door for bigger sales. A deceitful salesperson may even offer an artificially low price, secure your commitment (with paperwork, trial runs etc.) before revealing at the last minute that there had been a mistake in the calculation or an omission.
- Organizations soliciting donations may use surveys to ask if you'd be willing to help collect funds for charitable organizations, or use pleasantries to get you to agree that you're feeling great. To stay consistent with your responses, you're more likely to agree later to contribute to the less fortunate.
- During the Korean War, many American soldiers were captured as prisoners-of-war (POWs) by the Chinese communists and successfully "converted" using the consistency principle. The Chinese initially got the POWs to make small, seemingly harmless statements like "The United States is not perfect", then progressively got them to make bigger commitments (e.g. listing down problems in America and even writing essays on them).



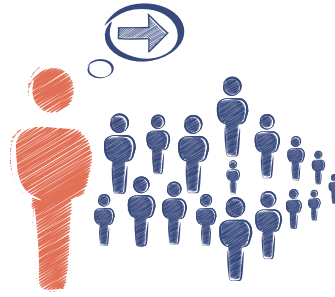
How to say no. The best way to avoid being manipulated is to become aware of it *before* we make a commitment.

- If you feel unsure about a situation, pause and ask, "Knowing what I know now, if I could go back in time, would I still make the same choice?"
- Then, pay attention to the first gut-impression that comes to you, before your logic kicks in. If your gut feel is one of discomfort or uncertainty, put aside your inclination to stick to past commitments and take time to review the facts.

KEY QUOTES

"When it occurs unthinkingly, consistency can be disastrous."

Social Proof



When we're uncertain how to behave or react, we look to others for answers.



Generally, this rule-of-thumb is useful for quickly figuring out norms or acceptable behaviors. We assume that if lots of people are doing something, it must be correct.



This principle is being applied widely in our daily lives.

- For example, TV-shows and comedies use canned laughter because it's proven to make the audience laugh more and works even for lousy jokes. Clubs create artificially long queues to give the impression that they are packed. Advertisers use "fastest-growing" or "best-selling" to signal that certain products are popular. Tip jars and donation boxes filled with some money tend to encourage people to tip or donate more.
- This principle is the most powerful when we are emulating the behavior of people who are similar to us. That's why many testimonials feature the average-person-on-the-street.
- Social proof can even help to overcome phobias—children who were afraid of dogs overcame their fear after repeatedly watching a video of a child happily playing with a dog. The clips were more effective if they showed a variety of children playing with dogs.



"Pluralistic ignorance" is a phenomenon where a large group of people go along with something they personally disagree with, but incorrectly assume is acceptable because others also do it. In a tragic incident, a woman was attacked near her house for more than 30min and eventually killed with multiple stab wounds. 38 people watched the attack from their own homes, yet no one called for help until the woman was dead.

- This happened because: (a) when there are many people around, everyone assumes someone else will help, so no one takes action, and (b) when people around us seem calm and unflustered, we infer that the situation cannot be an emergency.

KEY QUOTES

"In general, when we are unsure of ourselves, when the situation is unclear or ambiguous, when uncertainty reigns, we are most likely to look to and accept the actions of others as correct."

"We will use the actions of others to decide on proper behavior for ourselves, especially when we view those others as similar to ourselves."

- Pluralistic ignorance is most common in a large group of strangers, who try to look poised and dignified in front of others. It's thus likely to occur in urban settings, which are confusing, populous, with people who are less familiar with one another.
- If you're ever caught in an emergency, the best strategy to get help is to (a) be clear and specific about the help you need and (b) assign 1 person in the crowd to take action, e.g. "You, sir, in the blue shirt. I'm having a heart attack. I need help. Call the ambulance now."



This copycat behavior or herd instinct is so strong that it can even extend to aggression and suicide.

- After news coverage of a black fighter losing a heavyweight championship, there was a marked increase in the homicide rate for young black victims (but not white victims) in the next 10 days. Likewise, when a white fighter lost a match, more young white men (but not black men) were killed in the next 10 days.
- More than 2 centuries ago, a German novel (in which the hero committed suicide) was banned after the story triggered a wave of suicides in Europe. Today, front-page suicide stories are usually followed by a spike in deadly accidents (which Cialdini believes are suicides masked as accidents so insurance payouts won't be forfeited). In fact, the profiles of drivers in the accidents match those of the news coverage. News articles about a young person's suicide are followed by a surge of accidents involving young drivers, while news about an older person's suicide are followed by a surge of accidents involving older drivers.



How to say no. It's useful to learn from others so long as the feedback is valid and valuable to us. Beware 2 types of social proof:

- Intentionally-falsified social evidence, e.g. fictitious testimonials, bogus statistics. Cialdini urges us to expose and take strong action against such tricksters so they can't continue to deceive others.

KEY QUOTES

"Your best strategy when in need of emergency help is to reduce the uncertainties of those around you concerning your condition and their responsibilities."

"The mentality of a herd makes it easy to manage. Simply get some members moving in the desired direction and the others...will peacefully and mechanically go along."

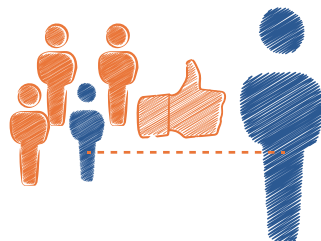
"The principle of social proof is so wide-ranging and powerful that its domain extends to the fundamental decision for life or death."

"Whenever possible we ought to sting those responsible for the rigging of social evidence."

- Erroneous social evidence, e.g. pluralistic ignorance or when certain actions/trends are replicated in a way that no longer makes sense. Periodically examine the evidence around you, like how a pilot monitors his instrument panel and environment instead of depending fully on the auto-pilot.

Liking

Generally, we're more likely to agree to someone's request if we know and like the person.



 Friendships and personal relationships bring a sense of connection, safety and obligation, which influence our choices.

- Tupperware parties are a great example of how various weapons of influence are put to use. They evoke the *reciprocity* principle via upfront games and prizes, gain *commitment* by asking participants to share how they've used and benefited from Tupperware, offer *social proof* of people buying Tupperware at the parties and tap on the rule of *liking* by having your friend invite you to the party.
- A relationship can be leveraged even if the person is not physically present—one common tactic is through referrals. A salesperson gets a customer to admit that he/she likes a product, then asks for names of friends who'd also benefit from it. When the salesperson contacts the prospects, it's harder for them to say "no" to a friend's recommendation.

 This principle works even if there are no established friendships—you simply need to get someone to like you. There are several factors that can predictably influence likability:

- Physical attractiveness. Good-looking people have an unfair social advantage because we unconsciously associate physical appeal with positive traits like talent, honesty, kindness, and intelligence. Attractive people are more likely to get help or change others' opinions. They even receive lighter sentences in criminal trials and higher-than-average compensations.
- Similarity. We tend to like people who are similar to us (in background, interests, opinions, age, religion, personality

KEY QUOTES

"An automatic-pilot device, like social proof, should never be trusted fully...it can sometimes go haywire by itself."

"The attraction, the warmth, the security, and the obligation of friendship are brought to bear on the sales setting."

"A halo effect occurs when one positive characteristic of a person dominates the way that person is viewed by others. And the evidence is now clear that physical attractiveness is often such a characteristic."

etc.). You can get someone to like you better simply by dressing like him/her or claiming to share similar interests.

- Compliments. When someone praises us, we tend to view him/her favorably, even if the praise is clearly inaccurate or comes with vested interests.
- Contact and cooperation. Generally, we like what's familiar. The more we're exposed to something, the more we're predisposed toward it, so long as (a) the exposure doesn't involve bad experiences (in which case familiarity can bring dislike) and (b) the other party seems to cooperate with us. Studies found that racial differences are more easily overcome when students of different races have to pool resources and cooperate to achieve a common goal. In law enforcement, the Good Cop-Bad Cop approach is commonly used to make the suspect like and cooperate with the "Good Cop".
- Conditioning and association. Our feelings toward people are affected by what we associate them with, e.g. we dislike people who bring us bad news even if they've not caused the news. That's why advertisers use celebrities and attractive models to associate their brands with beauty and desirability, and politicians try to associate themselves with positive news about job creation or advancement projects, even if they've not contributed to it.



All of us also unconsciously associate ourselves with success to look and feel good.

- People get emotional and defensive over their local or favorite sports teams because they associate themselves with the teams and take the wins and losses personally. On the day after a match, more people are likely to wear the winning team's jersey than the losing team's.
- We tend to use "we" when describing a successful project, and use "they" when describing a failure.
- Certain people (especially those with low self-esteem) tend to persistently drop-names to sound more successful or powerful.

KEY QUOTES

"We are phenomenal suckers for flattery... we tend, as a rule, to believe praise and to like those who provide it, oftentimes when it is clearly false."

"An innocent association with either bad things or good things will influence how people feel about us."



How to say no. It's hard to stop yourself from liking others. Instead, learn to identify when someone is deliberately using the rule of likability on you.

- Once you notice the feeling of strong liking for someone, ask yourself: In the time that you've known this person, is there reason for you to like him/her as much as you do?
- Even if you realize you like the person more than you'd have expected, don't assume you're being manipulated. Instead, make a deliberate mental effort to separate the person from the request he/she is making.

Authority



Each one of us, to varying degrees, is wired to obey figures of authority.



- Structure and authority are an integral part of how our society functions; without it, there'd be confusion and anarchy.
- Authority also offers a short-cut to decision-making, i.e. we let others do the thinking for us and simply get rewarded for following orders.



However, blind obedience is obviously undesirable.

- In an experiment, participants were instructed by an authority figure in a lab coat to administer increasingly larger voltages to another person, to supposedly study the relationship between pain and learning. Most participants followed orders even when the voltages reached fatal levels on the meter and the subjects were screaming and begging them to stop. [In reality, no charges were released in the experiment.]
- Many studies also found that doctors' orders in hospitals are followed blindly, even when the instructions obviously didn't make sense.



There are several symbols that reliably trigger our compliance to authority, and can be used to influence our choices and behaviors.

KEY QUOTES

"In making a compliance decision, it is always a good idea to keep separate our feelings about the requester and the request."

"We don't have to think; therefore we don't."

- Titles. We respect titles that take years of hard work and successes to acquire. Yet, it's relatively easy for con-men to forge credentials, or artificially improve their perceived status through related factors like size, height or other outward signs of power.
- Clothes. People wearing guard uniforms and business suits have been found to exert more influence over others. When a man wore a well-tailored business suit, he had 3.5x more pedestrians following him when he jaywalked, compared to when he dressed in normal clothes.
- Trappings. Other symbols of position and status (e.g. jewellery, prestige cars) also affect how we perceive and react to others.



How to say no. The best way to neutralise this principle is simply to be mindful that authority symbols can be faked.

- Scrutinize the source of authority, bearing in mind that it's a common trick for compliance practitioners to admit to a small flaw or weakness just to appear sincere and honest.
- Ask 2 key questions:
 - i. Is this authority truly an expert? Filter out hollow symbols and examine if the credentials are valid and relevant.
 - ii. How truthful can I expect this expert to be? Consider if he/she is truly credible and objective.

Scarcity



Generally, we perceive something to be more valuable when it's limited in availability.



Human beings value choices and freedom, and are naturally **loss-averse**, i.e. we are more motivated not to lose something, than to gain something.



We also use an item's availability to **gauge its quality**.

- We value something more if we see its quantity reduced before our eyes, compared to if it had been scarce from the

KEY QUOTES

"Titles are simultaneously the most difficult and the easiest symbols of authority to acquire."

"When our freedom to have something is limited, the item becomes less available, and we experience an increased desire for it."

onset. Downtrodden people who've always lived in deprivation tend to accept their fate, whereas those who experience a period of improvement followed by a sharp decline are more likely to rise in a revolution. Children whose parents give them privileges without consistent rules also tend to become more rebellious.

- We desire something the most if it seems to be less available due to demand or competition. That's why advertisers play up "by popular demand" or show queues of people flocking to snap up their goods. Property agents deliberately arrange for multiple prospects to view a house simultaneously. Even romantic pursuits seem more intense if there's a rival involved.
- Things that are banned also tend to be more desired. When information is censored, people not only want the information more, but tend to believe it more. Juries who were told not to consider a piece of information in a trial ended up using it even more.



There are several common sales tactics used to scare prospects into buying immediately so they won't lose a deal. The salesperson may tell you that there's only a *limited number* of products left, that an opportunity or offer is *expiring soon* ("limited promotion ends today!"), or you have to buy *right now*, because the price will go up or the item will no longer be available.



How to say no. When we encounter scarcity, our emotions take over and we're less likely to evaluate the situation thoughtfully.

- The first step is to become aware of your emotional arousal. Learn to scan your inner reactions so you're alert when someone is deliberately rousing you using scarcity tactics.
- Then, evaluate the situation in 2-steps: (i) Stop and calm yourself first, then (ii) ask yourself why you want that item. Scarcity may increase the value of possessing something, but doesn't improve its utility, i.e. a cookie won't taste better or satisfy your hunger more just because it is scarce. If you're buying something for consumption, consider its utility value so you won't give it an irrationally high value.

KEY QUOTES

"Not only do we want the same item more when it is scarce, we want it most when we are in competition for it."

"We react to information restriction...by valuing the banned information more than ever."

"In each instance, the intent (is) to convince customers of an item's scarcity and thereby increase its immediate value in their eyes."

"The joy is not in experiencing a scarce commodity but in possessing it. It is important that we not confuse the two."

"We must remember that the item under consideration will function equally well whether scarce or plentiful."



Conclusion & Details in the Book to Look Out For

Each of these principles offer shortcuts to decision-making, but can also be used against us if we're not mindful. You can use the insights from this book to positively influence others and while protecting yourself from deception.

The book is full of detailed case studies and examples to explain each of the 6 principles, illustrate how and why they work, and how they can be used against us. For more details, please visit www.influenceatwork.com.

About the Author



Robert B. Cialdini (born 1945) is the Regents' Professor Emeritus of Psychology and Marketing at Arizona State University. He was previously a visiting professor at Stanford University, as well as at the University of California at Santa Cruz. Cialdini received his Bachelor of Science degree from the University of Wisconsin, earned his Ph.D. in Social Psychology at the University of North Carolina and received Postgraduate training in Social Psychology at Columbia University.

KEY QUOTES

"With the proper understanding of the nature of our opponent, we can come away from the compliance battlefield unhurt and sometimes even better off than before."